

The Cough Decoder

Tell the difference, and know when it is an emergency.

What the Sound Is Telling You

The sound, timing, and triggers give clues, but they are not a diagnosis on their own. Use this to decide how urgently to act, not to treat at home.

Cough Sounds Like	When It Happens	Could Point To
Dry goose honk	Excitement, exercise, collar pulling	Collapsing trachea (small breeds)
Harsh, explosive, sudden	After boarding, daycare, dog parks	Kennel cough
Soft, wet, muffled	At night or lying down	Heart disease, fluid in lungs
Gagging, retching	Like coughing up a hairball	Throat or airway irritation

GO TO AN EMERGENCY VET NOW IF YOU SEE: trouble breathing or fast / heavy breathing, blue, gray, or pale gums, collapse or extreme weakness, or coughing up blood. These can be life-threatening.

Call Your Regular Vet Within a Day If:

- The cough lasts more than a few days or keeps getting worse
- Your dog is tired, off their food, or reluctant to exercise
- A senior dog has a soft, wet cough that is worse at night
- A small breed has a chronic honking cough
- Your puppy or senior dog has any persistent cough

The 30-Second Home Check (Resting Breathing Rate)

One of the most useful things you can track is your dog's resting breathing rate. While your dog is asleep, count how many full breaths (in and out is one) they take in 30 seconds, then double it.

Breaths Per Minute (asleep)	What It Suggests
Under 30	Normal resting range
Consistently 30 to 35+	Call your vet, can be an early sign of fluid in the lungs
Climbing day to day	Track it and call your vet, do not wait for distress

WHY THIS MATTERS: With heart disease the cough is often a LATE sign. A rising resting breathing rate can warn you days before a crisis, giving your vet time to help. This simple count can save your dog's life.